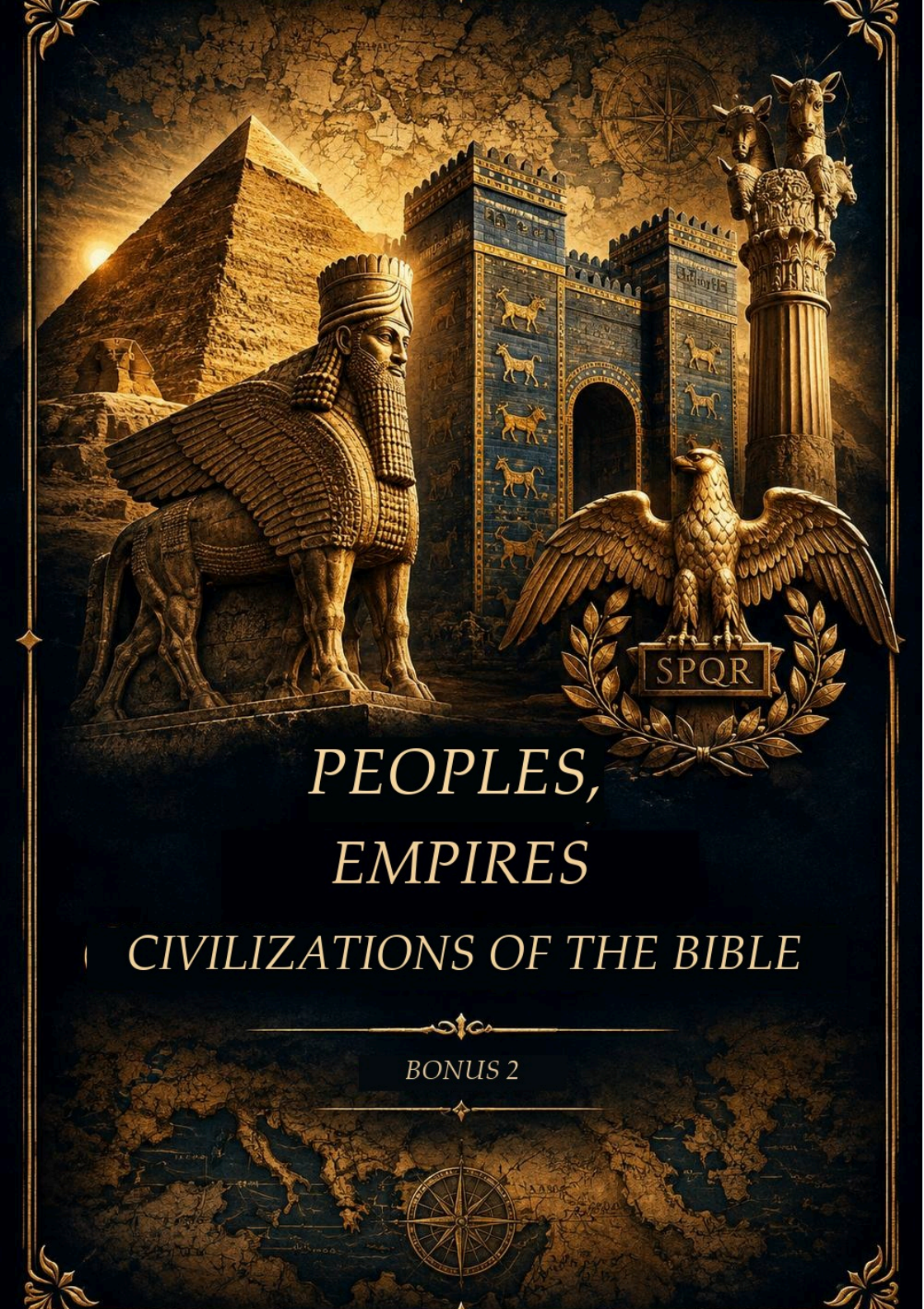


PEOPLES, EMPIRES

CIVILIZATIONS OF THE BIBLE

BONUS 2

BONUS 2

Peoples, Empires & Civilizations of the Bible™

Who were the neighbors, enemies, and rulers among whom the history of Israel and the first Christians unfolded.

The Bible did not appear in a vacuum. Its pages are filled with pharaohs and Canaanite kings, Philistine warriors, Assyrian tax collectors, Babylonian astronomers, Persian officials, Greek generals, and Roman governors. Once you get to know these peoples, many stories suddenly come into focus: you will understand why Abraham went down to Egypt, why David first had to defeat the Philistines, and what exile by the rivers of Babylon really meant.

In this guide we walk through twelve peoples and empires in an order that lets you follow the timeline from the Bronze Age to the New Testament era. Each section shows where a people came from, what they did, how they related to Israel, and where to find them in the biblical text. Dates are approximate and marked with “c.”, and the graphic reconstructions are an artistic interpretation based on archaeological research.

01

The Egyptians – Land of the Pharaohs on the Nile

NILEDELTA;C.3000BC–332BCINCONTACTWITH ISRAEL



Egypt was the first great power the ancestors of Israel encountered. The life of the land depended on the Nile: yearly floods fertilized a narrow strip of earth, so the state stored grain even in lean years. That is why, in times of famine, people from Canaan went down there for food. The story of Joseph, and later of the Israelites' stay in the land of Goshen on the eastern edge of the Delta, fits this setting (Gen 37–50).

The Book of Exodus describes the release from slavery and the march through the Sinai desert (Exod 1–15). The exact dating of the Exodus remains debated: scholars propose a period around the 15th or the 13th century BC. Later, Egypt appears in the Bible as an ally on whom the people of Judah relied despite the prophets' warnings, and also as a refuge, as shown by the flight of the Holy Family in the Gospel of Matthew (Matt 2).

- The Nile flows from south to north, about 6,650 km long

- Hieroglyphic script; officials also wrote on papyrus
- The pharaoh was the ruler of the state and the central figure of worship
- The land of Goshen lay in the eastern Delta

WHY WAS EGYPT THE REGION'S GRANARY?

Egypt depended not on rainfall but on the flooding of the Nile. When drought ruined the harvests in Canaan, grain could still be bought along the Nile. This climate difference explains why so many biblical stories of famine send their heroes toward the Delta.

02

The Canaanites – Dwellers of the Promised Land

CANAAN (TODAY'S ISRAEL, PALESTINE, LEBANON); C. 3000–1200 BC

Canaan is the name of the region lying between the Mediterranean Sea and the Jordan valley. Its inhabitants lived in city-states ruled by local kings, which often competed with one another. This fragmented structure meant the land easily fell into the orbit of Egypt, and later of other powers. Cities such as Jericho, Megiddo, Hazor, and Lachish were centers of trade and crafts, surrounded by walls that protected residents from attackers.

The Bible describes the Canaanites as neighbors, and, after the Israelites entered the land, also as rivals for the land (Josh 1–12; Judg 1). Canaanite religion worshiped Baal, Asherah, and other fertility gods, and worship often took place on hilltops. The prophets repeatedly warned Israel against mixing faith in Yahweh with these practices. Excavation results confirm that the material culture of the Israelites developed gradually, in contact with the Canaanite.

- The alphabetic script derives from the Canaanite-Phoenician sphere
- City-states ruled by kings, often dependent on Egypt
- Main deities: Baal, El, Asherah
- Important centers: Megiddo, Hazor, Lachish, Jericho

THE AMARNA LETTERS

Clay tablets with correspondence from Canaanite rulers to the pharaoh, dating to the mid-14th century BC, have survived in Egypt. In them the rulers complain about their neighbors and ask for support. They show what the political landscape of Canaan looked like just before the time of the judges.

03

The Philistines – People of the Coast

COASTAL PLAIN; C. 1175–600 BC



The Philistines settled on the southern coast of Canaan around the 12th century BC, most likely as part of the wave of the Sea Peoples from the Aegean region. They built five main cities: Gaza, Ashkelon, Ashdod, Ekron, and Gath. They stood out for their material culture: distinctive pottery, iron weapons, and good military organization. For the Israelites they were a dangerous adversary, because they controlled the trade routes along the coast.

The stories of Samson, Eli, Samuel, and Saul show the tension between the Israelites settling in the hill country and the Philistines of the plain (Judg 13–16; 1 Sam 4–7). David's clash with Goliath took place in the Valley of Elah, on the border of the two worlds (1 Sam 17). Only David's reign brought a breakthrough and an end to the threat (2 Sam 5). The Philistine cities survived until the Assyrian and Babylonian periods.

- Five cities: Gaza, Ashkelon, Ashdod, Ekron, Gath
- They were ruled by lords called seranim

- They knew ironworking, which gave them a military advantage
- The name Palestine comes from them (from Peleshet)

WHERE DOES THE NAME PALESTINE COME FROM?

The Hebrew word Peleshet meant the land of the Philistines. In Greek and Roman antiquity the name was extended to a larger area, from which later Palestine derives. It is an example of how the name of a single people can survive for millennia.

04

The Amalekites, Edomites, Moabites, and Ammonites – Neighbors to the East and South

NEGEV, TRANSJORDAN; C. 1500–500 BC

Around Israel lived several culturally related peoples. The Edomites, regarded in tradition as descendants of Esau, inhabited the mountainous country south of the Dead Sea (Gen 36). The Moabites and Ammonites settled on the highlands of the eastern bank of the Jordan, while the Amalekites were semi-nomadic tribes roaming the Negev and Sinai. All these peoples had their own kings, gods, and national pride.

Relations with them varied. The Amalekites attacked the Israelites in the desert (Exod 17); Moab was at first an enemy, yet it was from there that Ruth came, the great-grandmother of David (Ruth 1–4). Wars were fought with the Ammonites in the days of the judges and kings (Judg 11; 2 Sam 10–12), and Edom long wavered between rivalry and dependence. The prophets announced judgment on these peoples, yet the Bible also shows many of their people in a human light, not only a hostile one.

- Edom: capital in the Seir mountains, in tradition descendants of Esau
- Moab: highlands east of the Dead Sea
- Ammon: capital Rabbah, today's Amman
- Amalekites: semi-nomadic tribes in the Negev

RUTH THE MOABITE

The Book of Ruth tells of a woman from Moab who chose loyalty to her mother-in-law and embraced the God of Israel. She became the great-grandmother of King David. It is a reminder that in the Bible national borders do not close the way to a covenant with God.

05

The Arameans – People of Damascus and the North

SYRIA; C.1100–732 BC

The Arameans formed a network of city-states in what is now Syria, with Damascus as the most important center. Their language, Aramaic, spread widely as a language of trade and diplomacy. After the fall of the Aramean states it remained in use until Persian times, and in the 1st century AD it was also spoken in Palestine. Israel's ancestors had family ties with the Arameans, as the creed about the wandering Aramean recalls (Deut 26).

In the period of the kingdoms, Israel and Damascus sometimes fought each other and sometimes formed alliances against a common threat from Assyria (1 Kgs 20; 2 Kgs 5–8). The story of Naaman, the Aramean commander healed by the prophet Elisha, shows more personal encounters as well (2 Kgs 5). The Arameans were finally subdued by Assyria, which captured Damascus in 732 BC.

- Capital: Damascus, one of the oldest cities in the world
- Aramaic became the lingua franca of the Near East
- Parts of the books of Daniel and Ezra were written in Aramaic
- Jesus probably used Aramaic in daily life

THE LANGUAGE OF JESUS

Most scholars believe that Jesus spoke Aramaic, and some of his words have been preserved in the Gospels in that form, such as "Talitha koum" (Mark 5). Thanks to this, we can hear today echoes of the speech of Galilee from two thousand years ago.

06

The Assyrians – The Empire Without Mercy

MESOPOTAMIA; C. 900–612 BC



Assyria, centered on the upper Tigris, created in the 9th–7th centuries BC the first fully organized empire in the region. Its strength lay in its army, efficient administration, and a policy of deporting conquered peoples, which weakened their local identity. Capitals such as Kalhu and Nineveh were adorned with reliefs depicting war scenes and royal hunts. Many of them survive to this day and can be seen in museums.

The Bible describes Assyria mainly as an instrument of judgment on Samaria and Judah. In 722 BC the Northern Kingdom fell, and its inhabitants were partly deported (2 Kgs 17). Sennacherib stood at the walls of Jerusalem in the reign of King Hezekiah (2 Kgs 18–19; Isa 36–37). On the other hand, the Book of Jonah describes how the prophet was sent to Nineveh and the city repented (Jonah 1–4). This shows that the God of the Bible cares for all nations.

- Capitals: Ashur, Kalhu, Nineveh

- Fall of Samaria: c. 722 BC
- Sennacherib's siege of Jerusalem: c. 701 BC
- Fall of Nineveh: c. 612 BC

HEZEKIAH'S TUNNEL

Before the siege, King Hezekiah ordered a tunnel cut through the rock to bring water from the Gihon spring into the city. The structure is about 530 m long and can still be walked through today. It is one of the best-preserved traces of preparations for war with Assyria.

07

The Babylonians – The City of the Gates of the Gods

MESOPOTAMIA; C. 626–539 BC



Babylon, lying on the Euphrates, became the capital of a new empire after the fall of Assyria. Its greatest ruler, Nebuchadnezzar II, expanded the city: he built a processional way, the Ishtar Gate faced with blue glazed brick, and massive walls. The Babylonians were also famed for astronomy and mathematics based on the sexagesimal system, traces of which are still seen today in the division of the hour into minutes.

For the Bible, Babylon is above all the place of exile. In 597 and 586 BC Nebuchadnezzar's armies captured Jerusalem, destroyed the temple, and carried off part of the population (2 Kgs 24–25; Jer 39). In Babylonia the psalms of exile were composed (Ps 137), the prophets Ezekiel and Daniel were active, and the surviving texts began to be gathered and edited. The experience of exile shaped Israel's religious identity.

- The Ishtar Gate, preserved as a reconstruction in a Berlin museum
- Capture of Jerusalem: 587/586 BC

- The sexagesimal number system
- The legend of the Tower of Babel is linked to Babylonian ziggurats

THE GARDENS OF SEMIRAMIS

Known as one of the wonders of the world, the Hanging Gardens of Babylon appear in the accounts of Greek authors, but their location has not been confirmed by excavations. It is a good example of caution: not everything that is famous is documented.

08

The Persians – The Empire of Tolerance and Return

IRAN AND THE NEAR EAST; C. 539–332 BC

In 539 BC Cyrus the Great captured Babylon and created the largest state the world had yet seen, stretching from Central Asia to Egypt. The Persians ruled through satrapies, that is, provinces governed by governors, and in general allowed conquered peoples to keep their own customs and worship. A royal postal service operated on the important routes, and coins and the Aramaic language made trade and administration easier.

For Israel the Persian era was a time of revival. Cyrus allowed the exiles to return to Judah and rebuild the temple (Ezra 1; Isa 44–45). Ezra and Nehemiah led spiritual and communal renewal, and the walls of Jerusalem were rebuilt (Ezra 7; Neh 1–6). The Book of Esther is set at the Persian court in Susa and tells of the deliverance of the Jews. The Persian religion, Zoroastrianism, may have influenced some ideas, though this is hard to settle conclusively.

- Cyrus captured Babylon in 539 BC
- Capitals: Susa, Persepolis, Ecbatana
- The Cyrus Cylinder, with a decree of tolerance, has survived
- The official language of administration was Aramaic

THE DECREE OF CYRUS

The Book of Ezra quotes an edict permitting the return to Jerusalem and the rebuilding of the temple. Similar policies of Cyrus toward other peoples are confirmed by the discovery of a clay cylinder from Babylon, though it does not mention the Jews directly.

09

The Greeks – Alexander, the Seleucids, and the Ptolemies

FROM 332 BC TO 63 BC



In 334 BC the young king of Macedonia, Alexander, set out east and within just a few years conquered the Persian Empire. In 332 BC he reached Palestine and Egypt, where he founded Alexandria. Along with his army came the Greek language, gymnasiums, theaters, and philosophy. This process, called Hellenization, changed the culture of the whole Near East and prepared the ground for the later spread of Christianity.

Although Alexander is not a central figure of the Bible, his empire is evoked in Daniel's visions (Dan 8; 11) and in the First Book of Maccabees (1 Macc 1). In Alexandria the Greek translation of the Scriptures, called the Septuagint, was made, and the first Christians used it. The New Testament was written in Greek, which allowed it to reach people from Spain to Mesopotamia. This is one of the most important results of Alexander's conquests. After Alexander's death in 323 BC his generals divided the empire: the Ptolemies ruled in Egypt, the Seleucids in Syria. Palestine lay between them and

from about 200 BC belonged to the Seleucids. Antiochus IV Epiphanes desecrated the temple and forbade the practice of the Law (1 Macc 1; 2 Macc 6), which sparked the Maccabean revolt.

- Alexander died in Babylon in 323 BC at about age 32
- Koine Greek became the common language of the region
- The Septuagint was produced in Alexandria from about the 3rd century BC
- Ptolemies in Alexandria, Seleucids in Antioch (Acts 11)

WHY GREEK?

Thanks to the conquests of Alexander and his successors, Koine Greek became the language of trade, administration, and learning. When the apostles proclaimed the Gospel, they could be understood by people from different countries. This is the practical reason the New Testament was not written in Hebrew.

10

The Romans – Masters of the New Testament World

FROM 63 BC TO C. AD 135 IN PALESTINE



In 63 BC Pompey captured Jerusalem and Palestine came under Rome's sphere of influence. The Romans ruled through governors and client kings, maintained legions, built roads and aqueducts, and collected taxes through local administrators. The Pax Romana, the relative peace within the empire, made possible the travel the apostles used, including Paul on his missionary journeys (Acts 13–28).

In the Gospels we meet centurions, tax collectors, and the governor Pontius Pilate, who sentenced Jesus (Matt 27; John 18–19). The emperor at the time was Tiberius (Luke 3). Tensions between the Jewish population and the authorities led to the war of AD 66–70 and the destruction of the Jerusalem temple. Another revolt, led by Bar Kokhba, was crushed around AD 135.

- Rome became an empire under Augustus (27 BC – AD 14)

- Pilate was prefect of Judea c. AD 26–36
- Destruction of the temple: AD 70
- The road network ran to hundreds of thousands of kilometers

PAUL'S ROMAN CITIZENSHIP

Paul of Tarsus was a Roman citizen and knew how to invoke it when he needed to defend his rights (Acts 22; 25). Because of this he could appeal to the emperor and make his way to Rome. Roman law was thus not only a burden but also a tool.

11

The Maccabees and Hasmoneans – The Last Independent State

C. 167 – 63 BC

In 167 BC the priest Mattathias of Modein refused to offer a sacrifice according to the pattern imposed by the Seleucids and began an armed uprising. After his death leadership passed to his son Judas Maccabeus, who in 164 BC recovered the temple and rededicated it. This event is commemorated to this day by the Jewish festival of Hanukkah (1 Macc 4; 2 Macc 10). His brothers Jonathan and Simon in turn strengthened the family's position.

The descendants of the Maccabees, the Hasmoneans, established an independent Jewish state. They combined priestly and royal authority, expanded the country's borders, and subjugated neighboring regions. Their rule was also marked by internal disputes and struggles for the throne, which made it easier for Rome to intervene in 63 BC. In this period the parties of the Pharisees, Sadducees, and Essenes took shape, known from New Testament times.

- The books of the Maccabees are included in the Catholic canon
- Judas Maccabeus rededicated the temple in 164 BC
- Hasmonean state: c. 140 – 63 BC
- Parties: Pharisees, Sadducees, Essenes

HANUKKAH

The Festival of Lights commemorates the rededication of the temple after its desecration. Candles are lit one after another on an eight-branched lampstand over eight days. The Gospel of John mentions Jesus in Jerusalem during the Feast of Dedication (John 10).

12

The Herods – Kings Under Roman Guardianship

C. 37 BC – AD 100

Herod the Great, ruler of Judea from 37 BC, was a skillful politician and a great builder. He expanded the temple in Jerusalem and built the port at Caesarea Maritima as well as the fortresses of Herodium and Masada. To the Romans he was a loyal ally, but to many of his subjects a tyrant who did not hesitate to remove rivals. The Gospel of Matthew links him with the story of the magi and the massacre of the innocents (Matt 2).

After his death the kingdom was divided among his sons. Herod Antipas ruled Galilee and Perea and had John the Baptist beheaded (Mark 6; Luke 23). Agrippa I persecuted the first Christians (Acts 12), and Agrippa II heard Paul's defense (Acts 25–26). The Herodian dynasty illustrates how local rulers balanced between the demands of Rome and the expectations of their own people.

- Herod the Great died c. 4 BC
- He built Caesarea Maritima and Herodium
- The expansion of the Jerusalem temple lasted several decades
- Antipas ruled Galilee c. 4 BC – AD 39

MASADA

A fortress on a rocky plateau above the Dead Sea, strengthened by Herod the Great, became the last point of resistance in the Jewish war. Excavations have uncovered palaces, storehouses, and a system of cisterns that help us grasp the scale of the undertaking.

SUMMARY

Overview Table

PEOPLE OR EMPIRE	REGION	ERA AND RELATION TO ISRAEL
Egyptians	Nile Valley, Delta	c. 3000–332 BC; refuge and slavery, the Exodus
Canaanites	Canaan, Levantine coast	c. 3000–1200 BC; inhabitants of the land, rivals for settlement
Philistines	Southern coast	c. 1175–600 BC; chief enemies in the days of the judges and Saul
Amalekites, Edomites, Moabites, Ammonites	Negev, Transjordan	c. 1500–500 BC; related neighbors and rivals
Arameans	Syria, Damascus	c. 1100–732 BC; allies and opponents of the kingdoms
Assyrians	Upper Mesopotamia	c. 900–612 BC; destroyed the Northern Kingdom
Babylonians	Lower Mesopotamia	c. 626–539 BC; destroyed Jerusalem, the exile
Persians	Iran, the whole Near East	c. 539–332 BC; return from exile, rebuilding of the temple
Greeks (Alexander, Seleucids, Ptolemies)	From Macedonia to India	from 332 BC; Hellenization, the Septuagint, oppression under Antiochus IV
Maccabees and Hasmoneans	Judea	c. 167–63 BC; revolt and independence

Romans and Herods	The whole Mediterranean world	from 63 BC; rule in the time of Jesus and the apostles

The twelve peoples and empires you have met show that the Bible is rooted in real history, full of conflicts, discoveries, and great transformations. Each of these civilizations left its mark in the text: in the names of cities, in images, in laws, and in language. The next time you pick up a given book, ask who was ruling the world at that time. The answer will often let you understand the meaning of the story far better.